

The hard and soft *g*

The letter *g* makes a hard sound when it appears before any letter other than *e*, *i*, or *y*. The soft *g* sounds like a *j*—as in *jelly*—and usually comes before the letters *e*, *i*, or *y*.



Some words have a **hard “g” sound** that is followed by an “e” or “i” sound. In such cases, the **letter *u*** is added to make a hard “g” sound, as seen in ***guess*** (the letter *e*) and ***guide*** (the letter *i*).

▷ Hard “g” sounds

The hard “g” sound is common in English. The word *glue* has a hard “g” sound because *g* precedes the letter *l*.

galaxy

igloo

green

lagoon

gullible

fragrant

▷ Soft “g” sounds

These words have a soft “g” sound. The word *gene* has a soft “g” sound because *g* precedes the letter *e*.

gene

angel

ginger

legible

gymnast

allergy

Words with both “g” sounds

There are some words that include a hard and a soft “g” sound. There are not many words in English that have both sounds.

geography

soft “g” sound



hard “g” sound

gorgeous

hard “g” sound



soft “g” sound

garage

hard “g” sound



soft “g” sound

gigantic

soft “g” sound



hard “g” sound

Hard *g* exceptions

Some words make a hard sound even if *g* precedes the letters *e*, *i*, or *y*. These exceptions to the rule just have to be learned, so, if uncertain, check the correct spelling in a dictionary.



These are some common exceptions to the hard *g* rule.